EVERY GOLDEN SCEPTRE IS BACKED BY A SABRE made of glinting steel. For Prime Minister Narendra Modi, that trusted gladiatorial lieutenant is Union home minister Amit Shah—the only one who ever gets to be named with him in one hyphenated breath. The rook that strikes frontally across the chessboard, the knight who moves in mysterious ways...Shah is both. Sometimes at the same time. On August 5, 2019, barely nine weeks into his new role, Shah pulled out a stunner by piloting the annulment of Article 370. Revoking Kashmir's special status was always a cornerstone of the BJP's politics, but obligatory mentions in the party manifesto had dulled it by repetition, causing not a ripple on the Jhelum. Modi-Shah had made bold to alter the status quo, on a dispute with a complex international flavour, in a way hitherto deemed impossible.

Managing the diplomatic fallout was the remit of his boss. What Shah had to tamp down on was any internal stirring of revolt. Kashmir had been restive ever since the 2016 killing of young Hizbul commander Burhan Wani—any recurrence of massive protests would have caused global face loss. The home minister left nothing to chance. Blanket security covered the Valley like winter snow, mobile internet was switched off for a five-month-long information blackout, former chief ministers Farooq Abdullah, Omar Abdullah and Mehbooba Mufti were put under preventive detention along with scores of others. The siege was as complete as it was sudden.

The upscaling of paramilitary presence had its payoffs. Just six months after the deadly Pulwama attack in 2019, militancy would go into hibernation. No major episode has marred the calendar till now; stray exceptions only proved the rule, This May, India even pulled off a G20 event in the Valley amid talk of last-minute venue changes. Statistics sketch a picture of normalcy eked out of the gloom. Clashes between the public and security forces—that staple of front-page photos—are down. So are the numbers of youths joining militancy. Between 2018 and 2022, the MHA claims, civilian killings fell by 23 per cent, deaths of security personnel by 66 per cent, and terror attacks/ encounters by 45 per cent. Tight vigil kept the borders antiseptic. The Centre today touts Kashmir as a 'tourist hotspot'. Tourist arrivals are said to have quadrupled from 600,000 in 2018 to 2.5 million. That's thousands of jobs.

Punjab, too, had to be managed. Its old wounds were showing signs of fresh bleeding: a socio-political landscape in ferment, the state police intelligence HQ targeted by a rocket-propelled grenade, gangland violence overlapping on old militant shadows, drugs and weapons being airdropped via drones in the border areas—and finally, a charismatic young radical troubling the waters. Under Shah, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) has been keeping an eagle eye on proceedings, with extraditions, probes and chargesheets.

Though the recent flare-up in Manipur has been a setback, the MHA has recorded a litany of successes in the Northeast. Many insurgent groups were drawn into dialogue; peace pacts were signed with Twipra rebels in Tripura (August 2019), and Assam's Bodos (January 2020) and Karbis (September 2021); the Bru-Reang refugees of Mizoram/Tripura got a settlement (January 2020); and the Assam-Meghalaya border flare-up was managed with a pact (March 2022). Even if the Naga Accord of 2015 awaits its logical conclusion, the "improved security situation" has allowed the Centre to withdraw the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA) from many parts of Assam, Nagaland and Manipur, though the recent Kuki-Meitei clashes came as a reminder of how fraught the peace is. The other big challenge has been Left-wing extremism (LWE). The MHA can take some credit here too. Data suggests LWE-related violence has declined by 77 per cent, from an all-time high of 2,258 incidents in 2009 to 509 in 2021. The geographical spread of Maoism has also shrunk, with only 46 districts affected in 2021 as compared to 96 in 2010.

Shah's to-do list brims over. The pandemic had put on hold the Census, the update of the National Population Register (NPR), and the rollout of the controversial Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA). J&K awaits electoral normalcy too. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

ARTICLE 370

Annulled in August 2019

Fall in terrorist incidents in J&K

153 (2019)

125 (2022)



No. of tourists who visited J&K in 2022

2.5 MILLION

G20 Tourism Working Group meet in Srinagar, May 2023

BUT...

- **No clear date for J&K polls**
- **No consensus on CAA or NRC**
- **Naga Peace Accord still hanging fire**
- **MHA's mediation couldn't stop violence in Manipur**